

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 26

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A boy's red kite is torn from his hand by a sudden gust at the seaside, and his father responds in a way he had not expected.

1

The red kite had cost my father a whole afternoon to build. I had watched him cut the dowel, glue the paper, and tie the long tail of knotted rags with the patient care he gave to everything. When he handed it to me on the morning of our trip, the kite was almost as tall as I was. I held it the way one holds a younger sibling — proudly, awkwardly, and with the secret fear of dropping it.

2

The beach that day was almost empty. A pale sun, the colour of weak tea, lay over the dunes; the wind was strong but steady, the sort of wind grown-ups call “good kite weather”. My father showed me how to run with my back to the sea, paying out the string in even loops, until the kite caught the air and rose. For perhaps fifteen minutes it climbed beautifully, a clean red triangle against the grey, and I felt — though I would not have used such a word — important. The string hummed in my hand like a living wire.

3

The gust, when it came, was not announced. There was no warning shift in the air, no darker cloud overhead. One moment the kite was tugging steadily; the next, it was wrenched upwards as though some impatient hand had yanked it. The string snapped at the spool with a small dry sound, almost polite, and the loose end whipped past my cheek. I shouted something — I do not remember what — and began to run.

4

I ran along the wet sand with the silly, hopeless determination of a child who has not yet learned that some things cannot be chased. The kite was already small, and growing smaller. It crossed the line of the surf, paused above the water as if politely waiting for me, and then was lifted away over the open sea. I

ran until my lungs burned and the breath sobbed out of me. When I finally stopped, my shoes were full of water and the kite was a red speck no bigger than a poppy seed.

5

My father caught up with me, walking. He did not say what I had been expecting all the way back along the sand — that I should have held the spool tighter, that I had been careless, that we should have checked the wind. He did not say anything for a long time. He simply stood beside me, his hand resting lightly on the top of my head, and looked out at the place where the kite had been. Then he said, quietly, “It was a good flight, wasn’t it?” — and that was all.

6

I should have been comforted, and in a way I was. But I think now that what I felt most of all, standing there in my soaked shoes, was a strange and unfamiliar weight. It was the first time I had understood that a thing could be loved, and made carefully, and lost in a few seconds — and that no one was to blame, and that there would be nothing to be done about it. The sea was very large. The kite was very gone.

7

We walked back together slowly. My father did not offer to build me another one, and I did not ask. I think he understood, as I was only just beginning to, that another kite would not be the same kite, and that the comfort of replacement is not always a comfort at all. He bought me a paper cone of hot chips at the kiosk on the way to the car, and we ate them sitting on a low wall, looking at the sea.

8

Long after we had got into the car, and the heater had begun to work, and the windows had clouded with our breath, I kept turning to look at the empty sky above the dunes. I knew the kite would not come back. I knew there was nothing up there to see. But I looked anyway, the way one looks for a face in a crowd after the train has already pulled away.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says he held the kite “the way one holds a younger sibling — proudly, awkwardly, and with the secret fear of dropping it.” Explain, in your own words, what this comparison tells us about his feelings towards the kite. [2]

From Paragraph 2

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that suggest the conditions at the start of the day were favourable for flying a kite. [2]

3. The narrator says the string “hummed in my hand like a living wire.” Explain how this language makes the kite seem alive to him. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator describes the sound of the string snapping as “small” and “almost polite.” What is **unusual** about this description, and what does it suggest about the moment? [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator says he ran with “the silly, hopeless determination of a child who has not yet learned that some things cannot be chased.”

(a) What does this tell us about how the **adult narrator** now views his younger self? [1]

(b) Why does the writer say the kite “paused above the water as if politely waiting for me”? [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The narrator lists several things his father did **not** say. Explain how this technique makes the father's actual response — "It was a good flight, wasn't it?" — feel more powerful. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

7. The narrator says he felt "a strange and unfamiliar weight." Explain, in your own words, what this "weight" actually was. [2]

8. The narrator ends Paragraph 6 with two very short sentences: "The sea was very large. The kite was very gone." What is the **effect** of using such short sentences here? [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. Why does the narrator's father **not** offer to build him another kite? [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator says he kept looking at the empty sky even though "I knew there was nothing up there to see." What does this tell us about how the loss of the kite has affected him? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]**Text 4: A feature article on the rise of noise pollution as a public-health issue.****1**

For most of the twentieth century, noise was considered a nuisance rather than a hazard. A neighbour's loud music or a passing motorcycle might earn a frown, but it would rarely earn the attention of a doctor. That view has begun to change. In 2018, the World Health Organization (WHO) classified environmental noise — chiefly from road traffic, railways and aircraft — as the second-largest environmental cause of ill-health in Western Europe, behind only air pollution. A growing body of evidence now links long-term exposure to traffic noise with raised blood pressure, increased rates of heart disease and even shortened life expectancy. Noise, it turns out, is not simply unpleasant. It is biologically expensive.

2

The mechanism is no longer mysterious. When the body is repeatedly exposed to loud or sudden sounds, even during sleep, it releases stress hormones such as cortisol and adrenaline. Over weeks and years, this low-level alarm wears on the cardiovascular system in much the same way that chronic stress at work does. A 2023 meta-analysis covering more than nine million people found that for every 10-decibel increase in long-term traffic noise — roughly the difference between a quiet suburb and a busy main road — the risk of ischaemic heart disease rose by about 8 per cent. The figure is small for any one person, but at the population level it is enormous.

3

The problem is, unsurprisingly, sharpest in dense cities. Singapore, Hong Kong, Seoul and many European capitals routinely record average outdoor noise levels above the 53-decibel daytime guideline issued by the WHO; in some districts, especially near elevated expressways, levels remain above the **night-time** limit of 45 decibels long after midnight. Night noise is particularly damaging because the body, although asleep, continues to register and react to it. Even sounds that do not wake a sleeper will pull them up out of deep, restorative sleep into shallower stages, leaving them less rested in the morning despite an unbroken eight hours in bed.

4

Children appear to be more vulnerable than adults. Several large studies, including the RANCH project across three European countries, have found that pupils whose classrooms sit near busy airports or motorways score, on average, several months behind their peers on reading-comprehension and memory tasks. The most plausible explanation is straightforward: a child trying to listen to a teacher, or to sound out an unfamiliar word, is competing with a constant background of low-level interference. Over years, the cognitive cost compounds. Sleep is affected too — paediatricians in noisy districts now routinely ask parents about traffic outside the bedroom window before they ask about screen time.

5

Governments have begun to respond, though unevenly. The European Union's Environmental Noise Directive requires member states to map noise levels every five years and to draw up "action plans" for the worst-affected areas. Singapore has introduced quieter road surfaces along selected expressways and tightened limits on construction noise after dark. Several cities, including Paris and Madrid, have piloted "noise radars" — microphone-equipped cameras that automatically fine vehicles exceeding decibel limits, in much the same way speed cameras catch speeders. The most ambitious cities have begun to designate "quiet zones" — pockets of parkland, residential lanes and hospital precincts where lower limits are enforced and through-traffic discouraged.

6

None of this removes the need for individual action. Public-health researchers stress that the cheapest and most effective interventions remain within reach of ordinary households: closing windows on the

side of a flat that faces a main road, choosing a quieter bedroom where possible, using soft furnishings to absorb sound, and — crucially — keeping personal listening devices below 60 per cent of maximum volume. The WHO estimates that more than a billion young people are at risk of hearing damage from prolonged use of headphones at unsafe levels. Unlike traffic noise, this is a category of harm that the listener controls entirely.

7

There is, finally, a cultural question. For a century, noise has been quietly accepted as the price of modern life — the rumble of traffic, the bark of a leaf-blower, the late-night siren — and to complain about it has often been considered fussy. The new evidence suggests that this resignation is misplaced. Quiet, it seems, is not a luxury for the wealthy or the rural. It is a basic ingredient of physical and mental health, no less important than clean water or clean air. Whether our cities can be redesigned to give it back to us, in any meaningful quantity, will be one of the more interesting public-health debates of the coming decades.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that, for most of the twentieth century, noise was considered “a nuisance rather than a hazard.” Explain, in your own words, the difference between these two ideas. [2]

13. The writer ends Paragraph 1 with the sentence: “Noise, it turns out, is not simply unpleasant. It is biologically expensive.” What is the **effect** of the phrase “biologically expensive”? [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, explain **in your own words** how repeated exposure to loud noise harms the body. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Give **two** reasons from Paragraph 3 why night-time noise is especially harmful to health. [2]

16. The writer puts the word **night-time** in italics. Why? [1]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer says that paediatricians “now routinely ask parents about traffic outside the bedroom window **before** they ask about screen time.” What does this detail suggest about how seriously noise is now taken? [2]

18. Explain, in your own words, why children are described as being “more vulnerable than adults” to traffic noise. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer compares “noise radars” to “speed cameras.” What is **effective** about this comparison? [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. What is the writer’s **tone** in the sentence: “Unlike traffic noise, this is a category of harm that the listener controls entirely”? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer claims that quiet “is not a luxury for the wealthy or the rural.” Give **two** reasons, from Paragraph 7, why he believes this. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the ways in which noise harms public health**, and **what is being done — by governments and individuals — to reduce that harm**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Prolonged exposure to noise harms public health by ...

— END OF PAPER —